ter and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam chief M.K. Stalin was among those who flagged off the yatra.

While the renewed talk of a grand alliance has enthused some of the Opposition parties, the electoral equations on the ground remain the same. There have already been several claimants to the leadership position, with Mamata, KCR and Nitish fashioning themselves as prime minister material. However, before they get to who will lead the alliance, the 'united' front will have to get the arithmetic right if it wants to take the battle to the BJP camp. It will finally boil down to marking of dominant territories and evolving a seat-sharing formula based on positions of strength. This is an area where the Opposition parties will have to do the maximum homework.

There are nine states—Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Maharashtra—where regional or non-Congress forces have dominated the electoral landscape. These states account for 266 Lok Sabha seats—the BJP won just 84 (or 31 per cent) of them in 2019. Even if the Opposition forces come together in these states, they are unlikely to gain much more from here. The BJP anyway has only a marginal presence in some of them, and drew a blank in Kerala and Tamil Nadu.

In fact, the challenge for the non-BJP parties will be to arrest the saffron party's growth in these states. The states where non-BJP parties can expect to gain from 2019 are Bihar, Maharashtra and West Bengal. In Bihar and Maharashtra, the BJP has lost two allies since then—JD(U) and a section of the Shiv Sena, respectively. In Bengal, the BJP failed to keep up the momentum in the 2021 assembly polls and has seen plenty attrition since.

Back in Telangana, KCR, who is facing a determined charge on his fortress from the BJP, is growing national ambitions even as he talks of a "federal front of regional parties" to take on the saffron cohort. He wants to morph his Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) into a 'Bharatiya Rashtra Samithi', a string of sub-regional parties in other states like Gujarat and Karnataka where Telugus have a significant presence.

While on paper, the Opposition parties have an edge in these nine states,

For the opposition parties, evolving a seat-sharing formula based on positions of strength will be critical in '24

success in 2024 will depend on how the top players in Bihar and Maharashtra—the JD(U), RJD, Congress, Sena and Nationalist Congress Party—flesh out their roles. Mamata, Nitish and Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha may dream of a post-poll alliance but have no common ground to forge one before the polls. In fact, their post-poll strength will be determined by the support—in terms of seat sharing—they receive from the Congress and RJD in their respective states.

In Uttar Pradesh, which has 80 LS seats—the highest among states—the opposition forces have failed to challenge the BJP in the past two general elections. Alliances in the past, be it the Sama-



ANI

COME TOGETHER Rahul Gandhi on Day 6 of his 'Bharat Jodo' yatra in Thiruvananthapuram

THE OPPOSITION REALM

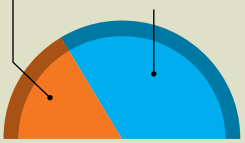
The BJP accounts for only 31 per cent seats In these states, leaving little scope for the Opposition to make further gains

Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Kerala

TOTAL LS SEATS 266

BJP **89**

Non-NDA parties **169**



BJP CITADELS

In the past two Lok Sabha electionls, the BJP's stunning majority came from its absolute domination in Uttar Pradesh in the north and Karnataka in the south. The two states together account for 108 seats and BJP walked away with 87 in 2019

Uttar Pradesh

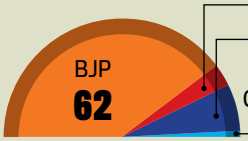
TOTAL LS SEATS 80

BJP **62**

SP **5**

BSP **10**

Cong. **1**



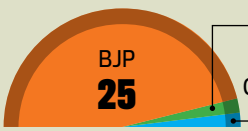
Karnataka

TOTAL LS SEATS 28

BJP **25**

JD(S) **1**

Cong. **1**



THE GAME OF 100

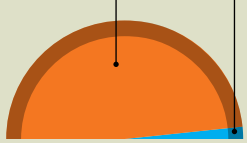
If the Congress can't reverse its fortune in these six states, all talk of an Opposition challenge in 2024 will remain just that

Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP and Chhattisgarh

TOTAL LS SEATS 100

BJP **97***

Congress **3**



Seat positions after 2019 LS election

*Includes one seat won by ally RLP in Rajasthan